10 SWAPS, AND WHAT TO DO IF IT HAPPENS IN FRONT OF EVERYONE

What to Say When Your Manager Gives You Tough Feedback

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1 When it lands, don't defend yet

Your first sentence decides if this turns into an argument. Buy yourself a minute.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Don't say: "That's not what happened."
> Instead say: "Okay. Let me make sure I get this."
>
> Don't say: "But I was told to do it that way."
> Instead say: "Got it. Can I ask a couple of questions first?"

You can push back later. Right now you're collecting facts.

2 Ask for the one moment

Vague feedback can't be fixed. Ask for one time it happened.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Don't say: "What do you mean, always?"
> Instead say: "Can you give me one example, like the Tuesday demo?"
>
> Don't say: "I don't think I do that."
> Instead say: "When did you last see it? I want to see it the way you did."

One real example is worth ten "you tend to"s.

3 Say back what you heard

Repeat it in one sentence so you both know you're fixing the same thing.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Don't say: "Okay, I'll work on it."
> Instead say: "So the issue is I gave a date in the demo before checking with eng. Right?"
>
> Don't say: "Noted."
> Instead say: "Let me say it back so I know I've got it."

If they correct your version, good. Better now than at review time.

4 Ask what good looks like

Get a picture of what they want instead.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "I'll do better."
> Instead say: "Next time, what would you want me to say in that moment?"
> Don't say: "Got it, won't happen again."
> Instead say: "What would it look like if I nailed this next month?"

Now you have a target, and you're not just avoiding a warning.

5 Close with one change and a check-back

Say what you'll do differently and when you'll check in.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Thanks for the feedback."
> Instead say: "I'll run dates by eng before demos. Can we check in after the next one?"
> Don't say: "Okay, cool."
> Instead say: "I'll try it in Thursday's review and ask you how it went."

Asking for the follow-up is how they remember you fixed it.

6 If it happens in front of everyone

Don't argue it in the room. Take the point and move the conversation.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "That's not fair, I wasn't even..."
> Instead say: "Fair point. Can we grab 10 minutes after this?"

Then, 1:1, ask for the next one in private: "Next time, can you tell me before the meeting?"

Check before you walk out

Run this before the conversation ends:

- [ ] Did you let them finish before you answered?
- [ ] Do you have one real example?
- [ ] Did you say it back in one sentence?
- [ ] Do you know what good looks like?
- [ ] Did you set a check-back date?